



This is Gateway's answer to Plasma TV. All 50 inches of it

financially. Plasma and LCD TVs from Dell, Gateway and the like, have undercut Sony's Trinitron offerings. Moreover, Apple with its phenomenally successful iPod personal-music player and the loss-leader iTunes music service has taken a large chunk off Sony's other pie—audio hardware such as Walkmans and Discmans. Even Dell has a personal MP3 player in the offering. Sony is reacting though; the PlayStation Portable (PSP) is touted as the Walkman for the next generation, while a low cost answer to the iPod is rumoured to be along the way.

Also of interest is the concept of a digital home—the ultimate in convergence where every device under your roof will be aware of every other device; talking with each other, sharing resources and generally making things easier for you. Central to the concept is the idea of a spoke—a PC with Ethernet and other connectors, ready to talk and rock—connected to other devices such as TV sets, refrigerators, microwave ovens, air conditioners, etc.

Samsung's Home Network Solution for example, has a backbone Internet connection that offers a single-point access to the Web and a skeletal intranet that connects myriads of devices.

A fingerprint recognition system protects the house, while a Web camera monitors the door for security purposes: when the doorbell rings, you can hit the remote and check out the visitor on your 42-inch Plasma TV, which is connected to a central PC-hub via a network switch (which also lets you connect all internal phone lines for an intercom system, offers Voice over IP for those long-distance calls and more). The switch interconnects the TV of the hall, the microwave and the fridge in the kitchen, the PC and the LCD of the bedroom to wall-access units; such that you can monitor and access all services from a central or non-central location.

For example, you can watch TV in

your bedroom, pause the program, surf the Internet, fire off an e-mail, print a web page, return to your program (done via PVR-capabilities of the Media Centre PC) all from one location... sweet!

Enough talk; time to take a closer look at some of these devices.

Archos Video AV380

Boasts of being the first handheld personal entertainment centre, rings true at a glance. The device combines a modular MPEG-4 video player and recorder, an MP3 music player and recorder, a digital camera, camcorder, a digital photo wallet and a data storage device—all in a form factor that sits in the palm of your hand.

With MPEG-4 video and an 80 GB hard disk, one can enjoy up to 160 hours of near-DVD quality video (640 x 368 at 25 fps) with MP3 sound. MPEG-4 recording lets you record off a TV, VCR or a camcorder, while a built-in microphone



enables you to use the AV380 as a voice recorder with 4,000 hours of capacity. The 3.8-inch colour LCD is a decent size for movies and pictures on the move. For larger screen requirements, the unit can connect to your TV set. Thanks to a USB 2.0 port, the device can be mounted as an external storage device on which you can store anything.

Home Hub

Remember the digital home? The Home Hub is central to such a concept, from Salton Inc.

An entertainment and command centre, it allows users to play Audio CDs, check the time, weather forecast and financial information, and acts as the gateway for other connected devices. Known as the Beyond Connected Appliances, these are: a microwave oven that can read the bar code of a food-package, access a database of recipes and cook it to



perfection; a coffee maker that can be programmed, via a point-and-click Web interface; and a bread maker that has a bar code reader similar to the oven, and puffs pastries to preset delight. The Home Hub connects to the Internet—via the Microsoft CE.NET operating system—and a Web site where its information is updated automatically. It is connected to the Beyond Appliances through a home's electrical wiring, allowing the appliances to also have their settings updated from the Web site.

Flipscreen

The Flipscreen is a device that aims to connect the kitchen to the rest of the world. Based on the Windows CE.NET OS and powered by a National Semiconductor Geode sc3200 CPU, this innocuous device will hang on to an available cabinet with élan. A 12.1-inch anti-glare, touch-sensitive LCD forms the central interface. With it, the Flipscreen can bring you TV channels, play DVD movies or CD Audio, surf the air for FM channels, and connect to an external camera to help you monitor the kids or the spouse as you cook.

A wireless keyboard and mouse let you control remote functionalities of

